

and mandate of legal tender. We believe that currency void of any physical representation is the next phase of the evolution, and in our Internet-tethered world an inevitable one.

As innovations underlying the Internet gained steam, so too did the realization that we would need a secure form of digital payment. One of Bitcoin's most famous ancestors was pioneered by a company called DigiCash, led by David Chaum, who remains one of the most famous cryptographers in cryptoasset history. In 1993, prior to Marc Andressen founding Netscape, Chaum invented the digital payment system called ecash. This allowed secure and anonymous payments across the Internet, no matter the amount.³

Clearly, Chaum's timing could not have been better given the tech boom that followed through the mid- to late-1990s, and his company, DigiCash, had several opportunities for growth, any of which might have made it a household name. However, while Chaum was widely regarded as a technical genius, as a businessperson he left much to be desired. Bill Gates approached Chaum about integrating ecash into Windows 95, which would have immediately given it global distribution, but Chaum refused what was rumored to be a \$100 million offer. Similarly, Netscape made initial inquiries about a relationship, but management was quickly turned off by Chaum's attitude. In 1996, Visa wanted to invest \$40 million into the company but were dissuaded when Chaum demanded \$75 million (if these reports are correct, it's clear that the potential price for Chaum's creation was dropping).⁴